

Parliamentary Procedure 101

In Congress there is a prescribed way on how to advance debate and act known as parliamentary procedure. The most important thing about parliamentary procedure is courtesy:

- Never break role-playing. Always refer to others as Senator/Representative (last name).
- Never communicate via the internet with others during the round.
- Always stand when addressing the chamber or making a motion.
- Never speak out of turn and discretely pass notes if necessary.
- Never leave/enter the room during a speech or during questioning or a speech.

If you are unsure about a motion or what to say, then remain quiet. Novices are urged to just observe parliamentary procedure, since you're not expected to motion at your first tournament. The following is a list of often used motions (which are addressed to the PO):

- ✗ **"I move to suspend the rules and add an additional (?) minute(s) of questioning...."**: This is used to add questioning after a speech if no questioning is allocated or if the time for questioning has elapsed. Adding one minute is customary. This is best done after the first negative speech, or a particularly good speech. Requires 2/3 majority.
- ✗ **"I move to suspend the rules and amend the docket and...."**: This is used to amend the docket and change the order of topics to be discussed through the day. Can only be amended after a full DEI cycle. Items can only be moved up the docket, never down. Requires 2/3 majority.
- ✗ **"I move to previous question"**: This ends debate on a topic and begins voting procedures. Requires 2/3 majority.
- ✗ **"I move to table this piece of legislation"**: This temporarily ends debate on a topic, but the topic can be taken off the table with a similar motion. Mechanism to postpone debate. Requires 1/2 majority.
- ✗ **"I call for a division of the house"**: Requests the chair to take a standing vote. Usually done when the vote appears close. Requires consent of chair.
- ✗ **"I move for a (?) minutes recess"**: Allows for a recess of a few minutes. Usually done between topics for five minutes or at the end of sessions for a predetermined amount of time. Requires 1/2 majority, but this is never a point of contention.
- ✗ **"I move to adjourn for the day"**: End Congress for the day. Requires 1/2 majority but is never a point of contention.

- ⊗ **“I move to make this an open chamber”**: Allows people to leave the chamber without asking permission. Some tournaments do not allow open chambers. Requires $\frac{1}{2}$ majority, but this is never a point of contention.
- ⊗ **“I move to open the floor for debate”**: This is used to start debate for the first time during a day. It doesn't actually exist (Some POs don't know that), so don't motion this.

The purpose of Student Congress is to debate legislation, not show off one's knowledge of parliamentary procedure. Take into consideration when contemplating any of the above action

There are also other parliamentary procedures which do not require motions (also addressed to PO).

- ⊗ **“I rise to a point of personal privilege.....”**
 - ⊗ “To exit the chamber”: Allows you to leave the chamber if it is not an open chamber
 - ⊗ “To re-enter the chamber”: Allows to you to come back in if it is not an open chamber
 - ⊗ “To address the chamber”: Allows you to speak to the chamber
 - ⊗ Miscellaneous, this could be a request of the chair, such as requesting to close the door, there is no specific wording for this
- ⊗ **“I rise to a point of order”**: used to correct a mistake the chair makes, such as speaking order error, voting error, or other error
- ⊗ **“I rise to a point of inquiry”**: to ask a question such as how much time is remaining in the session (avoid this unless absolutely needed).

A more formal list of motions is found below

When voting on motions, the PO will use procedural majorities. At the beginning of the day you count the number of people in the room and calculate $\frac{1}{2}$ and $\frac{2}{3}$. Round up always! If there is an even number in the room, add one to get the one-half majority. For example, for 12 competitors (with the PO):

$$\frac{1}{2}=7$$

$$\frac{2}{3}=8$$

You need that number of people to vote for the motion. You can't abstain from a procedural vote (motion votes).

When voting on legislation, you need more “yes” votes than “no” votes for the legislation to pass. For example, if the vote is 6 yes – 5 no – 2 abstain, the legislation passes. If you have an equal number of yes and no votes, the PO breaks the tie.

TABLE OF PARLIAMENTARY MOTIONS

Following is the National Speech & Debate Association motion chart, annotated (non-shaded) to show motions used most often.

Table of Most Frequently Used Parliamentary Motions Adapted for use in National Speech & Debate Association Congressional Debate			Second Required?	Debatable?	Amendable?	Required Vote	May interrupt?
Type	Motion	Purpose					
Privileged	24. Fix time for reassembling	To arrange time of next meeting	Yes	Yes-T	Yes-T	Majority	Yes
	23. Adjourn	To dismiss the meeting	Yes	No	Yes-T	Majority	No
	22. Recess	To dismiss the meeting for a specific length of time	Yes	Yes	Yes-T	Majority	No
	21. Rise to a question of privilege	To make a personal request during debate	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	20. Call for orders of the day	To force consideration of a postponed motion	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
Incidental	19. Appeal a decision of the chair	To reverse a decision	Yes	No	No	Majority	Yes
	18. Rise to a point of order or parliamentary procedure	To correct a parliamentary error or ask a question	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	17. Division of the chamber	To verify a voice vote	No	No	No	Decision of the Chair	Yes
	16. Object to the consideration of a question	To suppress action	No	No	No	2/3	Yes
	15. Divide a motion	To consider its parts separately	Yes	No	Yes	Majority	No
	14. Leave to modify or withdraw a motion	To modify or withdraw a motion	No	No	No	Majority	No
	13. Suspend the rules	To take action contrary to standing rules	Yes	No	No	2/3	No
Subsidiary	12. Rescind	To repeal previous action	Yes	Yes	Yes	2/3	No
	11. Reconsider	To consider a defeated motion again	Yes	Yes	No	Majority	No
	10. Take from the table	To consider tabled motion	Yes	No	No	Majority	No
	9. Lay on the table	To defer action	Yes	No	No	Majority	No
	8. Previous question	To force an immediate vote	Yes	No	No	2/3	No
	7. Limit or extend debate	To modify freedom of debate	Yes	Yes	Yes-T	2/3	No
	6. Postpone to a certain time	To defer action	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	Yes
	5. Refer to a committee *	For further study	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	Yes
	4. Amend an amendment *	To modify an amendment	1/3	Yes	No	Majority	No
	3. Amend *	To modify a motion	1/3	Yes	Yes	Majority	No
Main	2. Postpone indefinitely	To suppress action	Yes	Yes	No	Majority	No
	1. Main motion	To introduce a business	Yes	Yes	Yes	Majority	No

* No. 5 should include:

1. How appointed?
2. The number
3. Report when or to what standing committee

T = Time

* Nos. 3 and 4 by:

1. Adding (inserting)
2. Striking (deleting)
3. Substituting